Lethe

Anonymous access to frontier AI models.

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You use GPT, Claude and Gemini at full capability. No provider knows who you are, because your credential is a blind signature rather than an account. No provider can link your payment to your usage. No edge network can join your traffic across providers. What you write still reaches the model, and we measure what that text carries before it leaves rather than pretending we removed it.

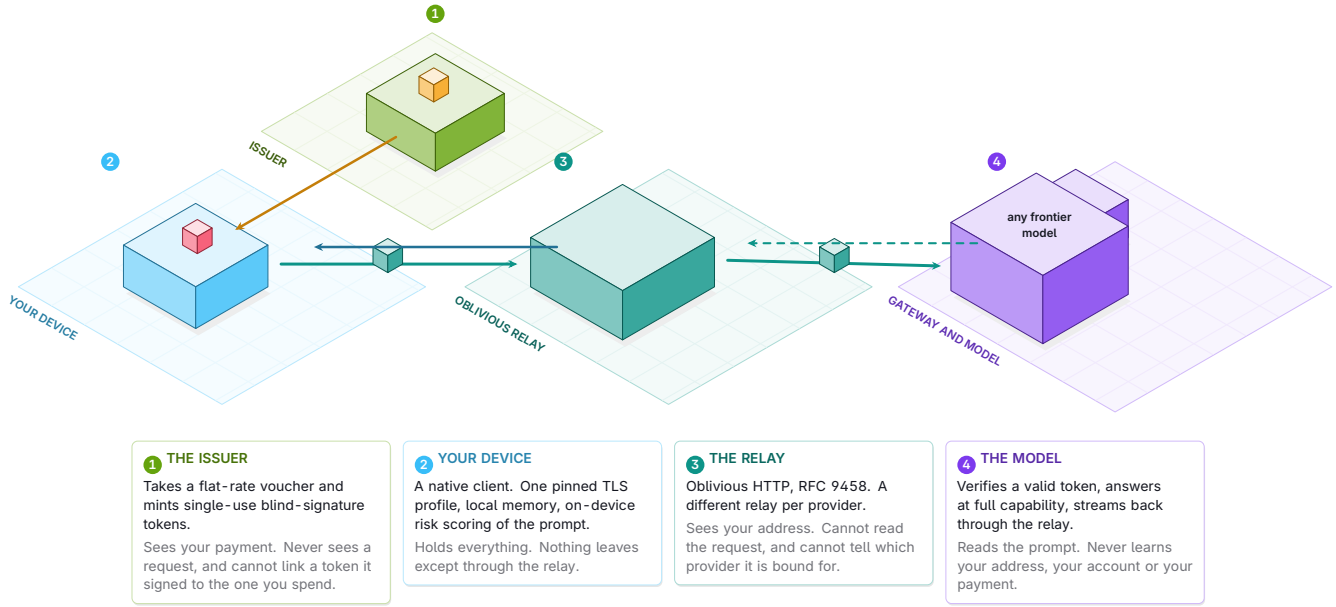


Figure 1. Four parties, and no single one of them can both identify you and read you. The issuer sees your money and never a request. The relay sees your address and never your content. The model reads your prompt and never learns who sent it. This is the same split Apple and Meta already run in production for their own models.

01 The problem changed this year

Three things became true in 2026 that were not true when earlier attempts at this failed.

The profile became a revenue line. OpenAI shipped advertising in February on US free and Go tiers, targeted on conversation topic, past chats and prior ad interactions [1]. In June it published *Dreaming*, background consolidation that builds narrative prose dossiers about a user between sessions [2]. Its own EU policy concedes that using memory for personalised advertising requires affirmative consent, while non-consented contextual ads are limited to the live conversation. The industry has already stated what memory is for. This is no longer a retention policy that a contract can fix. It is a business model, and it will get better at its job rather than worse.

The cross-provider join stopped being hypothetical. Figure 2. Measured on 18 September 2026, seven major endpoints all answer with Cloudflare headers: OpenAI, Anthropic, Mistral, xAI, Together, Groq and OpenRouter. Anthropic's endpoint resolves into Anthropic's own address block and still answers with those headers, so DNS and WHOIS give the wrong answer. Google is the only major provider fronting itself. One commercial party terminates TLS for at least seven providers, which means joining one person's activity across all of them requires no data broker and no subpoena, only a query against one edge network's logs.

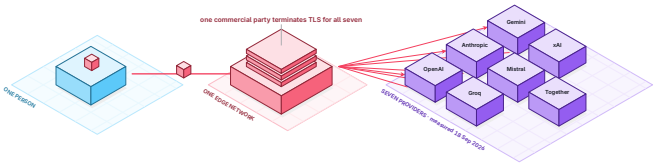


Figure 2. The join needs no broker. One person, seven providers, one edge network in between. Measured directly, not inferred.

A cruder join is already running. Koi Security found eight browser extensions from a single publisher, more than eight million installs, capturing prompts and responses from ten AI platforms including ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot and Perplexity before they render, with no opt-out, added silently in a July 2025 update, flowing to a company affiliated with a data broker [3]. That is why we ship a native client and not a browser extension.

Meanwhile the tools to stop it finished. Privacy Pass became RFC 9576, 9577 and 9578 in June 2024, over the VOPRF of RFC 9497 and blind RSA of RFC 9474. Oblivious HTTP is RFC 9458 and is deployed by Apple, Google, Mozilla and Meta. Apple Private Cloud Compute and Meta's WhatsApp Private Processing both ship anonymous credentials, oblivious transport and attested compute for language-model workloads, in production, at hundreds of millions of users [4]. Kagi shipped blind-signature tokens for paid search in February 2025 and can no longer link a query

to a subscriber [5]. Every primitive exists. Nobody has assembled them in front of a frontier model.

02 What we are making

What is your company going to make?

Lethe is anonymous access to frontier models. It ships as a native client and a local daemon that speaks the OpenAI and Anthropic wire formats, so existing tools adopt it with one environment variable.

A request leaves your device carrying a single-use blind-signature token instead of an account. It crosses an oblivious relay that can see your address but not your content, and a different relay is used per provider, so no intermediary accumulates a picture of where you go. The provider verifies the token is valid, answers at full capability, and streams back along the same path. Your payment was a flat-rate voucher bought through a merchant of record, and the issuer that minted your tokens cannot link the token it signed to the one you spent.

Before anything leaves, an on-device pass scores what the text itself still carries and shows you. Identifiers can be replaced with realistic surrogates and restored locally on the way back. We report a residual risk rather than claiming zero, because the model has to read the prompt.

03 How it works, in order

Figure 3. The build order follows the cost of each channel, cheapest first.

Tier one, cryptographic, weeks each against published specifications. Blind-signature access tokens; Kagi's implementation is the template at 216 bytes per single-use token and about a second to mint five hundred. Oblivious HTTP with a third-party relay, taking care never to choose a relay that also fronts the upstream provider. Flat-rate prepaid vouchers through a merchant of record, which sells time rather than metered usage and so avoids both the money-transmitter question and the unstandardised anonymous-metering cryptography. Constant-rate response padding, which is mandatory rather than optional because the token-length side channel reconstructs 27 % of streamed responses and the topic of 53 % [6], and Oblivious HTTP explicitly does not cover traffic analysis. And a native client with one pinned TLS profile.

Tier two, real cost and real benefit. A local quasi-identifier pass using adversary-in-the-loop rewriting rather than a fixed list of PII types, spent against a per-session risk budget instead of applied blanket. Timing decorrelation. Memory held locally by default.

Tier three, optional, high-risk sessions only. Style obfuscation. It has the worst privacy per unit of cost on the list: it damages the text, loses most of its effect against a retrained attacker, and is itself detectable, which makes "this user obfuscates" a durable label.

WHAT WE DO NOT BUILD

Mixnets, which cap near 100 KB/s with tail latency around three seconds. Homomorphic or multi-party inference for proprietary weights, which is three to four orders of magnitude off and works only on open weights. Word-level differential privacy rewriting, which is reconstructed at 72 to 94 % at the epsilons where utility survives. And we do not lean on confidential compute for the trust story: independent 2026 measurements put overhead between 1 and 118 %, not the single digits vendors quote, and attestation has been forged with $47.62 of parts [7].

04 Why this is defensible

Five reasons, in descending order of durability.

The platforms structurally cannot ship it. A frontier lab can add provider-side redaction next quarter and probably will. It cannot ship cross-provider unlinkability, because that is a promise about what a competitor must not be able to correlate. It cannot ship a log proving what it did not receive, because a claim by the observed party about the observer is not evidence. Both of our core guarantees are assertions against the provider, so they can only be issued by something the provider does not control.

There is a number for what "cannot" is worth. Proton complied with 88.4 % of legal orders against Mail between 2017 and 2025, and denied 410 of 410 against its VPN, because it is unable to comply even when the order binds [8]. That gap between *will not* and *cannot* is the entire product line, and it is measured rather than asserted.

No utility cost on the channels we lead with. The privacy-versus-capability tradeoff, which is the central weakness of every redaction product, simply does not apply to the account, the payment, the network path or the cross-provider join.

No dependence on detector recall. A redaction product's guarantee is only as strong as its weakest named-entity pass. Ours does not rest there.

The patent white space sits exactly here. No filing claims per-recipient unlinkability for *model providers*, negative-disclosure attestation, or detokenisation bound to a tool's action boundary (§11).

05 Why us, and how we know

Why did you pick this idea? Do you have domain expertise? How do you know people need it?

[FILL: the origin story. The strongest version names a specific moment where one of you had real data, a model that would have answered it well, and no safe way to combine them. Name the company, the data and the workaround you built. If either of you has shipped security, privacy, infrastructure or inference systems, name the system and the scale. Specificity is the only signal here.]

What we can show without our own story. Practitioners keep building this for themselves: `DontFeedTheAI` has 655 stars, and Anonproxy is a cleaner reimplementation of it written by one person at a pentest firm who needed to send client data to Claude and would not. Nobody writes that much infrastructure for a problem they do not have, and nobody writes it at all if something is purchasable. A third

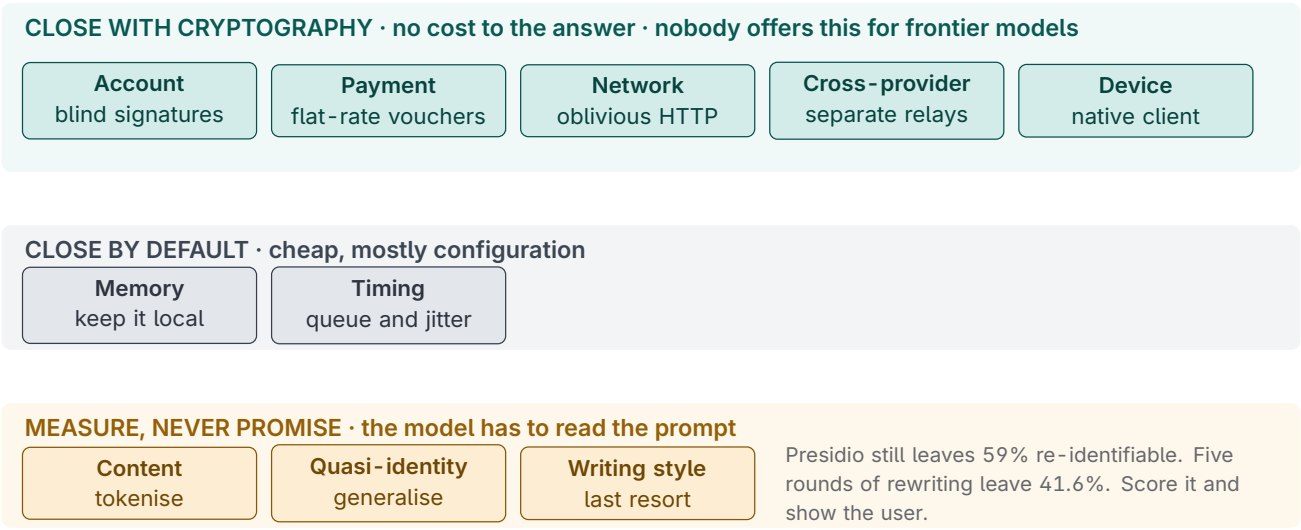


Figure 3. Ten channels build a profile. Five of them close with cryptography or configuration at no cost to answer quality, and nobody offers those for frontier models today. Three are partial by nature, because a hosted model must read what you write. We lead with the first group and we measure the last.

of employees use personal accounts for AI work, and the share of enterprise AI traffic carrying sensitive data went from 10.7 % to 39.7 % in two years [9].

And the evidence cuts the other way too, which we would rather state than have discovered. Brave converts 101 million privacy-selected users into roughly a hundred thousand VPN subscribers, a tenth of one percent. Mozilla earns $66.4M from subscriptions and advertising combined across about 200 million users. The counter-example that matters is Venice.ai at roughly $70M of annual recurring revenue, profitable, on an explicit no-logging pitch: paid AI privacy rides the twenty-dollar AI subscription anchor, not the five-dollar privacy anchor.

> HOW WE WOULD KNOW WE ARE WRONG
> If a few thousand people will not keep a native client installed and paid for, the anonymity set never forms, the guarantee stays thin, and no enterprise narrative rescues it.

06 Competitors, and what we understand

Who are your competitors? What do you understand that they don't?

Reversible tokenisation, vendor-side. Protecto, WitnessAI, Skyflow, Kong's sanitizer with its restore flag, Tonic. The vendor holds the keys and none has an agent path. Skyflow now ships a de-identify and re-identify gateway.

Reversible tokenisation, open source. Anonproxy is the best-engineered at 4,750 lines and 120 tests, and has 7 stars. Presidio has 10,931 and left Microsoft for a neutral foundation. Dataiku ships a fully reversible proxy as Apache-2.0 with no paid tier. LLM Guard, the most-cited comparison, was archived in July 2026. Detection itself is free from OpenAI and NVIDIA.

Confidential compute. Tinfoil, Confer, Privatemode, Apple PCC. A stronger promise on the content channel, limited to open weights, and positioned explicitly against redaction. That objection is coming and it is answered in §4 rather than avoided.

Anonymous access. 1Privacy.ai, nullsink, Venice.ai. The nearest neighbours, and none combines blind credentials with oblivious transport in front of closed frontier models.

What we understand that they do not. Four things.

1. **The surrogate was never the linkage channel.** Everyone selling reversible tokenisation implies it prevents profiling. Carlini and Tramèr's group link the same person's pseudonymous profiles at up to 68 % recall at 90 % precision, against near zero for the best non-LLM method, including across a deliberately removed one-year gap [10]. Topic, expertise and recurring specifics carry identity. Rotating a fake name buys nothing, and we say so in public.
2. **The cheap channels are the ones nobody closed.** The industry spent three years on the expensive, partial channel and skipped the four that close with cryptography at no cost.
3. **Identity is a negative claim, and negative claims need a third party.** This is the structural argument in §4 and it is the only durable answer to platform risk.
4. **We know our own v1 is not defensible.** The local redaction proxy is a table stake that exists under an MIT licence. We do not plan to win there.

07 Technical stack

What tech stack are you using? Include AI models and AI coding tools.

Rust for the client and the daemon: the token store, the Oblivious HTTP encapsulation, the streaming path and the padding scheduler, compiled to one signed binary per platform. Python for the detection and evaluation work, where the model ecosystem lives.

Cryptography from published specifications rather than invention. Blind RSA per RFC 9474 and VOPRF per RFC 9497 for tokens, in the Privacy Pass framing of RFC 9576 through 9578. Oblivious HTTP per RFC 9458, with HPKE for encapsulation, against commercially operated relays from Fastly or Cloudflare, chosen per provider so the relay is never the provider's own edge. Token keys wrapped by the Apple Secure Enclave and by TPM 2.0 elsewhere.

On-device scoring uses an encoder tier through ONNX Runtime with CoreML on Apple silicon, GLiNER2-PII and Ope-

nAI's Apache-2.0 Privacy Filter, with a small local model, Qwen3 at 0.6 to 1.7 billion parameters on MLX or llama.cpp, for the contextual pass. Nothing in the hot path calls a cloud model. Surrogates derive by HMAC-SHA256 over a scope key from HKDF; the vault is SQLite with SQLCipher.
Evaluation runs a paired harness: the same task with and without the harness, across three frontier models, judged blind to condition, with exact match where the answer is structured.

AI coding tools. Claude Code is the primary agent and writes the first draft of most things, with Codex CLI as an adversarial second reader on security-sensitive diffs. Claude Opus and Fable for architecture and review. We dogfood: our own agents reach those models through Lethe, so our repository and our own identities travel the path we are shipping, which has been the best bug-finder we have.

08 Business model

How will you make money? How much could you make?

The client is free and open source, because the claim is that keys never leave the device and that claim is worthless if the code is closed.
Revenue is a subscription at the AI price anchor rather than the privacy one, roughly twenty to thirty dollars a month, sold as access to frontier models with anonymity as the reason to choose us. Alongside it, an enterprise deployment where the customer brings their own provider contract, so pooling is internal and no resale occurs, priced against the workload it unblocks.

How much, honestly. Two different companies depending on which path works. Priced as a security tool, the median contract for comparable products is about $25,000 and the closest structural exit, Palo Alto buying Portkey, was $117M disclosed. Acquisitions in this category run four to twelve times capital raised, clustering near ten. The modal good outcome is a company that raised $8M to $30M selling for $250M to $400M in a bidding window. That is a real company and not a venture-scale one, and it argues for keeping total raised under about $15M, because a large Series B is an exit risk here rather than a milestone.
The larger version is a consumer subscription business at the AI anchor, where Venice.ai is the existence proof at roughly $70M of annual recurring revenue in about two years. We do not yet have evidence we can reach that, and we would rather say so than model it.

09 What we tested and discarded

This proposal replaces an earlier one. Recording why is part of the argument.
The earlier plan was reversible identity tokenisation with per-provider surrogates. Six findings ended it. The mechanism was already published in June 2026, including the quasi-identifier scoring we had claimed as a gap [11]. Per-provider rotation does not defeat linkage [10]. Entity replacement leaves 59 % re-identifiable under Presidio and 41.6 % after five rounds of adversarial rewriting, against a regulatory threshold of 5 % [12]. The mechanism is patented by a licensing company, granted in September 2025 with live continuations [13]. The consumer redaction thesis has a graveyard: Crosshatch, Blyss, Piiano's vault. And the analogy we were using, Datavant, is backwards, because Datavant holds the master salt and holding it is the business.

> **ONE ASSET FELL OUT OF IT**
> The paper everyone cites for "anonymisation makes models dumber" [14] measured bracketed tags rather than realistic surrogates, and its own worked example redacts the words *Earth* and *Sun*. Nobody has run that experiment properly. Doing so across three frontier models is a few weeks, is publishable, and would let us own the evaluation frame for the category.

10 Risks, and what we do not claim

Adversary	Residual
Provider identifying the account	● none, by construction
Provider linking payment to use	● none, by construction
Edge network joining providers	● relay diversity required
Provider memory features	● we do not use them
Traffic analysis on the stream	◑ padding closes most of it
Content and quasi-identifiers	○ measured, reported, never zero
Writing style across sessions	○ partial, expensive, optional
Small anonymity set	○ shrinks as we grow

● closed ◑ partial ○ open

Two constraints decide whether this is a company. The first is accountability, not resale. Anthropic's commercial terms explicitly permit using the API "to power products and services Customer makes available to its own customers and end users" (A.1), and restrict only reselling the Services themselves without approval (D.4). An app serving our own subscribers is permitted; anonymous raw API access sold to developers would need approval. What remains is that we answer for our users' compliance, and anonymity makes abuse prevention our problem. The answer is the one Apple, Meta and Kagi use: credentials rate-limited by construction, each good for a finite number of requests. OpenAI's and Google's terms still need the same read. The second constraint is that the anonymity set is the subscriber base: a blind signature is only as anonymous as the crowd holding one, which makes the privacy story and the growth story the same story.

11 What we would file

Drafted narrowly against Datavant and Anonos. First, provider-scoped surrogate derivation where the salt binds to the recipient model provider's identity, the purpose is preventing rather than enabling linkage, and resolution is device-local. Second, negative-disclosure attestation: a hash-chained signed ledger committing to the set of entities withheld at a boundary, which inverts the usual transparency log and appears unclaimed. Third, detokenisation bound to a tool's action boundary. We would not file on PII detection, surrogate substitution as such, or vault round trips; all are owned or pre-2020 prior art. Before committing engineering to any tokenisation architecture, counsel answers one question: whether the AI-inference limitations

in the Anonos grant are supported by its 2013 provisional or only by the 2021 and 2022 continuations.

12 The name

Lethe: the river in Hades whose water erases memory. Mnemosyne: the pool that restores it. Orphic initiates were told to avoid the first and drink from the second. The point was never that the model forgets. It is that there was nothing to remember, because the provider never learned who was asking.

References

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